THE MUMBAI WAR ZONE

Prominent contestants in the city's metropolitan region

MUMBAI SOUTH

Voters: 1.5 mn

Arvind Sawant *SS(UBT)* Vs Yamini Jadhav *SS*

Incumbent MP: **Arvind Sawant,** *SS(UBT)*

MUMBAI SOUTH CENTRAL

Voters: 1.45 mn

Rahul Shewale *SS* Vs Anil Desai *SS(UBT)*

Incumbent MP: **Rahul Shewale,** *SS*

MUMBAI NORTH CENTRAL

Voters: 1.7 mn

Varsha Gaikwad *Congress*

Vs

Ujjwal Nikam *BJP*

Incumbent MP: **Poonam Mahajan,** *BJP*

MUMBAI NORTH WEST

Voters: 1.7 mn

Amol Kirtikar *SS(UBT)*

Vs

Ravindra Waikar *SS*

Incumbent MP: **Gajanan Kirtikar** *Shiv Sena*



MILIND SHELTE

Shinde, and nominated Dr Hemant Savra to take on Bharti Kamdi of the Sena (UBT) and Rajesh Patil of the Bahujan Vikas Aghadi, a local formation. Kamdi has the Communists, who have a base in Dahanu and Talasari, to fall back on. This is a far cry from the 1960s and 1970s when the Sena was taking on the Left in Mumbai at the behest of the Congress.

In the textile town of Bhiwandi, the NCP (Sharadchandra Pawar) prevailed over ally Congress to get the seat to nominate Suresh 'Balya Mama' Mhatre against the BJP's Kapil Patil (Union minister of state) and Congress rebel Nilesh Sambare. Apart from some Congress leaders' ire, the division of the Aagri community vote between Mhatre and Patil and Kunbi support for Sambare may determine the outcome. However, Mhatre is said to be gaining support from Muslims, who constitute a significant portion of the population in Bhiwandi.

A senior leader of the deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar-led NCP says the delay in announcing the nominees from Palghar and Thane is likely to affect the Mahayuti's chances. "In Thane, there is a battle between the Modi factor and the Thackeray factor," says journalist and analyst Sandeep Pradhan. "If the Modi factor does not work and the narrative about the Sena being split does, it will help Thackeray."

Who's the 'Real' Sena?

Despite the Election Commission of India (ECI) recognising the Shinde faction as the real Shiv Sena and granting the name and the bow and arrow symbol to it in February 2023, the Thackeray faction continues to insist that it is the original Sena. "The peoples' mandate will decide which is the real Sena," says veteran Sena (UBT) leader and former minister Subhash Desai. Argues a Mahayuti source: "This is a battle between Thackeray and Shinde to determine the real Shiv Sena, and also between Thackeray and the BJP, which is blamed for engineering the split in the party."

AT STAKE ARE INDIA'S FINANCIAL CAPITAL AND THE CASH-RICH BMC. THE MAHAYUTI AND MVA ARE ALSO SEEKING TO CONTROL THE FAST-URBANISING MUMBAI METROPOLITAN REGION

However, Manisha Kayande, MLC, Shiv Sena, says the issue of Shinde's faction being the Shiv Sena was settled after the ECI's decision. "We are seeking votes based on the work done by the Modi regime and the Maharashtra government," she says. "The state government has taken around 500 pro-people decisions in two years.... But they (the rival Sena) are trying to give their campaign an emotional twist. Do such issues matter for the people?"

According to Pratap Asbe, journalist and analyst, the results of the Lok Sabha election will settle the real Shiv Sena and NCP debate once and for all. "There is sympathy for Thackeray after the split in his party. The politics of splits in Maharashtra and those who are accused of graft eventually getting positions of power will have a popular resonance," he adds.

New Social Coalitions

MVA leaders claim that Mumbai and its neighbouring areas will gain from a 'MaMu' or Marathi-Muslim consolidation in its favour. While the six constituencies in Mumbai may have about 650,000-700,000 Marathi speakers each, the Muslims number around 200,000, varying from around 500,000 in Mumbai North Central to over 350,000 in Mumbai South, says former Congress minister Aslam Shaikh. The Bhiwandi and Kalyan seats have a substantial Muslim population